

BEYOND THE KINGDOM

Episode #0001

"The Premiere"

Air Date: Monday, January 3, 2005

Prod. #BTK-0001

Story Day: Monday, January 3, 2005 (7:38 AM - 11:47 PM
EST)

Teleplay by the Beyond the Kingdom Writers' Room
Final Shooting Script

CAST OF CHARACTERS – EPISODE #0001

(ages as of Monday, January 3, 2005)

THE DONOHUES: SIMONE DONOHUE (94) · VICTOR DONOHUE (68) · JOAN DONOHUE (66)

THE OLSONS: JASMINE DONOHUE OLSON (44) · DR. PETER OLSON (45) · MARTIN OLSON (23) · MALLORY OLSON (19)

THE BULLOCKS: ROBERT BULLOCK (45) · NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK (43) · CHIEF ELXA BULLOCK JACKSON (24) · DET. JEREMY JACKSON (24) · MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (22) · GRACE BULLOCK (20)

THE SMILLEYS: ODESSA SMILLEY (84) · LUCIUS SMILLEY (55) · VIVIENNE SMILLEY (49) · DESMOND SMILLEY (48) · LUKE SMILLEY (28) · DELPHINE SMILLEY-ASHE (25) · ESTHER SMILLEY (22) · QUENTIN SMILLEY (21) · EMMA SMILLEY (2) · VICTORIA SMILLEY (2)

THE CIRCLE: AMOND BAKER (22) · ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22) · HARMONY DIVINE (22) · LYRIC SOLACE BAKER (2)

RECURRING: CELESTE VAUGHN (24) · MAYOR JOSEPHINE WHITAKER (55) · DEPUTY CHIEF WARREN HUGHES (46) · WINSTON FAIRLEY (62) · RUBY "NANA RUBY" TOLLIVER (66) · BRIELLE SUTTON (21) · BEATRIX "NANNY BEA" PENNINGTON (43) · THADDEUS CROWE (40)

DAY PLAYERS: NURSE TONYA · KEYONNA (7) · DEANDRE (9) · DOG WALKER · MEDICAL EXAMINER · APD OFFICER · REPORTER #1 · REPORTER #2 · SMILLEY AIDE · SMILLEY DRIVER · ASSISTANT DA PRESTON · WBKG ANCHOR (V.O.)

MENTIONED, NOT SEEN: Alvin Donohue (in Miami) · Theodore Donohue (in Monaco) · Sebastian Kingsley (in London) · Roman Gaines (in Sri Lanka, heard by phone)

FADE IN:

TEASER

1 EXT. BUCKHEAD — PEACHTREE ROAD — PRE-DAWN

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:36 AM EST

Blue-black sky. Peachtree Road is empty except for a street sweeper and one MARTA bus, lit up like a lantern.

Two skyscrapers face each other across the road like chess pieces.

On the east side: DONOHUE TOWER. Eighty-eight stories of limestone and bronze glass. A gold crown is set into its crest.

On the west side: a brand-new seventy-two-story tower of silver glass. Every window is dark. A shroud hangs over the name at the top.

**INT. DONOHUE TOWER — VICTOR'S OFFICE — 88TH FLOOR —
CONTINUOUS**

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:38 AM EST

A cathedral of an office. Mahogany. A wall of windows. Above the fireplace hangs the PORTRAIT OF ALEXANDER DONOHUE in his prime, his hand resting on a hotel ledger.

VICTOR DONOHUE (68) stands at the window with his hands folded behind his back. He looks a decade younger, silver only at the temples. He's in shirtsleeves and suspenders, with a cup of black coffee going cold on a chessboard beside him.

He's watching the dark tower across the road.

The door opens without a knock. Only one person in the world does that.

NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK (43) enters. She looks thirty-three. A cream coat is over her shoulders, and she carries two fresh coffees and a leather folio. She's the CEO of the most valuable company on Earth, and she walks like she knows it.

NATASHA

You slept here.

VICTOR

I rested here.

NATASHA
Mama's going to kill you.

VICTOR
Your mother has been killing me
for forty-five years. I'm very
durable.

She swaps his cold cup for a hot one and joins him at the
glass.

NATASHA
Sunrise is 7:42. Their press
release says "the tower will wake
with the sun."

VICTOR
Poetic.

NATASHA
Vivienne wrote it. You can smell
the perfume on the fax.

Victor almost smiles. He picks up the BLACK KING from the
chessboard and rolls it between his fingers.

The FIRST SLIVER OF SUN cuts across Buckhead.

Across Peachtree, the silver tower WAKES. Floor by floor,
bottom to top, the windows ignite in a rolling wave of
white light. It's spectacular, and it's a declaration.

At the crest, the shroud DROPS from the name:

SMILLEY

Lit in platinum. Aimed directly at Victor's window.

Natasha exhales through her nose. Victor doesn't move.

NATASHA
Well. That's tacky.

VICTOR
That's a message.

NATASHA
Do we answer it?

VICTOR
(setting the king down
in the center of the
board, click)

We don't answer, Natasha. We remind.

He sips his coffee. Across the road, the SMILLEY sign burns like a second sun.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
Call your mother. Tell her to wear the pearls tonight.

NATASHA
Which ones?

VICTOR
The ones she wore in 1963. Simone will know what it means.

Natasha studies her father, and whatever she sees worries her.

CUT TO:

2 EXT. BELMONT CREST — THE RIVER GATE DOCK — MORNING
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:44 AM EST

The CHATTAHOOCHEE RIVER runs wide and slow below the wooded bluffs. At this hour the water is black, with a thin mist rising off it.

An old stone BOATHOUSE. A wooden dock.

At the end of the dock, in a gray Morehouse hoodie and running shorts, stands MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (22). He's beautiful in a way that makes people forget what they were saying. He's barefoot on freezing wood in January because he forgot his shoes are on the bank.

He's skipping stones. A sleek satellite phone is pressed to his ear.

MARC
(into phone)
No, Roman, listen to me. I don't care what it costs. If the village needs water purifiers, send the purifiers. If they need the helicopter, send the helicopter. If they need the pilot to sing "Amazing Grace," tell him to warm up.

INTERCUT WITH:

**EXT. GALLE, SRI LANKA – RELIEF CAMP – EVENING (6:44 PM
LOCAL)**

A devastated coastline, a week after the tsunami. Rows of white BSI CRISIS RESPONSE tents. Generators hum. Families wait in line for water.

ROMAN GAINES (28), a quiet mountain of a man in BSI black, speaks into a satellite phone.

ROMAN
(a smile he'd never
admit to)
Helicopter's already fueled.

MARC
I know. I heard it three minutes
ago. You were testing me.

ROMAN
Somebody has to.

MARC
How many kids in the camp?

ROMAN
Four hundred and twelve. As of
tonight.

Marc stops skipping stones.

MARC
(soft)
Get them shoes. Real shoes, not
donated junk. New ones, every
size. And a birthday party for
any kid with a birthday this
month. Cake. Balloons. A clown if
you can find one who isn't scary.

ROMAN
Marc, it's a disaster zone.

MARC
That's exactly why they need a
party.

END INTERCUT.

Footsteps pound down the bluff path. AMOND BAKER (22), sharp-featured and fit, with the stillness of someone who's always calculating, jogs onto the dock completely out of breath.

AMOND
(wheezing)
You said six-thirty.

MARC
(into phone)
Roman, my right hand just arrived
an hour late and he's dying. I
have to go.
(hangs up)
I said six-thirty to see if you'd
come at seven-thirty. You came at
seven-forty-five. Growth.

They look out at the black water. The mood shifts.

AMOND
They open this morning.

MARC
I know. Granddaddy slept at the
office so he could glare at it
personally.

AMOND
You scared?

MARC
Of a family that spells "smiley"
wrong on purpose? Terrified. I'm
shaking. Look at me.
(holds out a perfectly
steady hand)

AMOND
I'm serious. They didn't move a
whole company to Atlanta for the
weather.

MARC
No. They moved it here for us.
(beat)
Let 'em come. I love company.
I'll make a pound cake.

Marc reaches into his hoodie pocket and pulls out
something small and dark. A polished BLACK ONYX COIN,
engraved with a CROWN ABOVE A WAVE.

He flips it into the air. It spins, catching the first
sunlight. He catches it without looking.

Amond watches the coin disappear back into the pocket and says nothing. Neither does Marc.

MARC (CONT'D)
Come on. Great-grandma Simone's
got grits and judgment waiting,
and I'm late for both.

CUT TO:

**3 EXT. DEKALB-PEACHTREE AIRPORT — PRIVATE TARMAC —
MORNING**

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:58 AM EST

A white GULFSTREAM with a silver "S" on its tail rolls to a stop. Three black Maybachs wait on the tarmac. So do a dozen men in dark suits.

The man in charge is THADDEUS CROWE (40). He's ex-Secret Service, with an earpiece and a face like a locked door.

The stairs descend.

First out is NANNY BEATRIX "BEA" PENNINGTON (43), a crisp Englishwoman in a camel coat with a diaper bag slung like a rifle.

Then a tiny blur in a pink puffer coat rockets past Bea's knees and down the stairs. It's VICTORIA SMILLEY (2), a wild child, already running toward the jet engine.

BEA
Miss Victoria! We do NOT sprint
toward the turbine!

Crowe steps into Victoria's path. She dodges him like a running back. He actually looks impressed.

Then a hand SCOOPS her up mid-stride.

ESTHER SMILLEY (22).

She's the kind of beautiful that stops conversations in other rooms. It's effortless, and it's all natural. She wears a black cashmere coat and dark sunglasses, with a toddler under one arm like a handbag.

ESTHER
(to Victoria)
What did we say about running
from Mommy?

VICTORIA
(delighted)
Run FASTER!

ESTHER
That is not what we said.

Behind them, EMMA SMILLEY (2) carefully descends the stairs one step at a time, holding Bea's hand. She's solemn and wide-eyed, and she clutches a picture book.

EMMA
(to Bea, precise)
There are fifteen steps.

BEA
Very good, Miss Emma.

EMMA
The pilot said fourteen. He was wrong.

Esther kneels, setting Victoria down but keeping a firm grip on her hood. She gathers both girls in front of her. For a moment the ice is gone. She's just a young mother.

ESTHER
Girls. Look.

She points. Twenty miles south, the ATLANTA SKYLINE glows in the fresh sun. And in the middle of it, catching light, is the new silver tower.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
That's ours.

VICTORIA
All of it?

ESTHER
Not yet.

EMMA
It's cold.

ESTHER
(standing, sunglasses
back on)
Not for long.

CROWE

Miss Smilley. Your father would
like you at the Tower by nine.
The ribbon-cutting is at ten.

ESTHER

Then we'll be there at
nine-fifteen, and he'll pretend
to be angry.
(beat)

Take West Paces Ferry.

CROWE

Northside is faster.

ESTHER

I didn't ask what was faster.

Crowe opens the car door. She buckles each girl into a car
seat herself.

CUT TO:

**INT./EXT. SMILLEY MAYBACH – MOVING – WEST PACES FERRY ROAD
– CONTINUOUS**

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 8:31 AM EST

Old Buckhead rolls past: stone walls, magnolias, mansions
set far back on sloping lawns.

The twins are distracted. Emma is "reading" her book to
Victoria. Victoria is trying to eat it.

Esther stares out the window.

The car passes a long, high wall of Georgia fieldstone
that runs for what seems like a mile. Then, set back from
the road, a GATE:

THE CROWN GATE OF BELMONT CREST.

Two limestone guardhouses. Twenty-four-foot wrought-iron
gates crowned with a gilded "BC." And on the left pillar,
clearly visible, a dark SCORCH MARK with a bronze PLAQUE
beneath it.

ESTHER

Slow down.

The DRIVER slows. Esther lowers her window.

Through the gate, down a long tree-lined drive, the rooftops of great houses rise on the bluff.

Her face is unreadable. Her hand drifts to the car seat beside her, and rests on Victoria's small sneaker.

VICTORIA

Mommy, who lives there?

A long beat.

ESTHER

(quiet)

Nobody we know.

At the guardhouse, a BSI GATE OFFICER in black steps out and looks at the idling Maybach.

ESTHER (CONT'D)

(window rising)

Keep driving.

The Maybach pulls away. Behind it, the gold crown on the gate catches the sun.

SMASH CUT TO:

MAIN TITLES – "KINGDOM"

(Extended premiere version – 90 seconds. See Document 12.)

ACT ONE**4 INT. THE DOWAGER HOUSE — MORNING PARLOR — MORNING**
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 8:40 AM EST

The first house ever built in Belmont Crest: Creole galleries, tall shuttered windows, and everything painted a soft New Orleans yellow. Photographs crowd every surface, a hundred years of Donohues. A silver coffee service. A bowl of grits, a plate of biscuits, and a jar of fig preserves.

At the head of a small breakfast table, in a lavender silk robe with her silver hair pinned perfectly, sits SIMONE TOUSSAINT DONOHUE (94). She looks seventy. Her spine is straighter than the chair's.

She's reading the Atlanta Sentinel through gold lorgnette glasses. The headline:

INSERT — THE ATLANTA SENTINEL, MONDAY, JANUARY 3, 2005:
"SMILLEY TOWER OPENS TODAY — CHICAGO DYNASTY PLANTS FLAG
ACROSS FROM DONOHUE EMPIRE"

Marc enters, showered now, in a charcoal suit with his tie hanging undone. He kisses her cheek from behind.

MARC
Morning, Gorgeous.

SIMONE
(not looking up)
You're eleven minutes late, and
you smell like river.

MARC
I showered.

SIMONE
You showered after the river. The
river is still in there. It gets
in the soul.

He sits. She pours his coffee before he can reach for it.
She has done it for twenty years.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
Tie.

MARC
I was going to—

SIMONE

Tie.

He leans forward. She ties it for him with quick, expert fingers. It's a small, practiced ritual.

SIMONE (CONT'D)

There. Now you look like money instead of a boy who plays in the river.

She taps the newspaper.

SIMONE (CONT'D)

They're lighting the thing at sunrise. Did your grandfather see it?

MARC

Granddaddy slept at the office so he could watch it personally. Mama's up there with him now. I think they're planning a war.

SIMONE

They're planning a breakfast. The war was planned in 1952.

(beat)

Is Odessa coming?

MARC

The paper says "the entire Smilley family."

SIMONE

(to the ceiling, or to God)

Lord. I'll need my good pearls.

MARC

You met her once, right? Mama says it's a legend.

SIMONE

We spoke for ninety seconds in 1963 at an NAACP dinner in Washington. She said my dress was "very brave for a woman my age." I was fifty-two.

MARC

What'd you say?

SIMONE

I said hers was very brave for a woman with her figure.

(sips coffee)

Then I asked the orchestra to play "Stormy Weather," because it was her signature song, and I sang it better.

Marc CACKLES and nearly chokes on a biscuit.

MARC

Gorgeous, you're a menace.

SIMONE

I'm ninety-four. I'm entitled to be a menace. I've earned it by surviving.

She studies him over her glasses.

SIMONE (CONT'D)

Wednesday.

MARC

Wednesday.

SIMONE

Twenty-three.

MARC

Twenty-three.

SIMONE

So. When are you giving me great-great-grandbabies?

MARC

Gorgeous, it's eight-forty in the morning.

SIMONE

Babies don't care what time it is. That's the whole problem with them.

Marc leans back. This is the thing he loves most, and it shows. His whole face softens.

MARC

You want the truth?

SIMONE

I'm too old for anything else.

MARC

I want so many kids we need a bus.

SIMONE

A bus.

MARC

A gold bus, with my face on the side. And every Sunday I drive it up Sovereign Way, honking, and everybody on the Summit has to come out and wave.

(beat, quieter)

I want a big table, Gorgeous. Bigger than Granddaddy's. So loud nobody can hear themselves think. Kids under it, kids on it, kids swinging from the chandelier—

SIMONE

Nobody is swinging from my chandelier.

MARC

—from MY chandelier. I'll buy one for swinging.

(beat)

I want them to never, ever have to earn their place at the table. I want them born sitting at it.

Simone sets down her cup. For a long moment she just looks at him.

SIMONE

Your great-grandfather used to say that. Almost word for word.

MARC

Yeah?

SIMONE

"They closed every door, so I built the house." And then he'd say: "Now I need somebody to fill it."

(beat)

He chose you, you know. Not because you were the smartest,

though Lord knows you are.
Because you were the one who
looked at a table and counted the
empty chairs.

Marc doesn't have a joke for that.

Through the window behind them, across the garden, stands a dark brick Tudor with shuttered windows and dead leaves on the steps. It's ASHGROVE, and it's clearly been empty a long time.

Simone's eyes drift to it.

MARC
Two months, right? Till Uncle
Theo's allowed back?

SIMONE
The exile ends in March.
(beat)
But Theodore has never arrived
anywhere on time. He arrives on
purpose.

She turns back to her grits.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
Eat. You have a board meeting,
and you'll walk in late, and your
cousin Martin will make that
face.

MARC
What face?

SIMONE
The one he's been making since he
was nine. Like somebody put salt
in his Kool-Aid.

Marc laughs and eats.

CUT TO:

5 INT. BELLE RIVE — KITCHEN — MORNING
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 8:52 AM EST

The Bullock estate: a Mediterranean palazzo on the river bluff. The kitchen is huge, warm, and chaotic. Copper pots, a twelve-burner range, and the smell of bacon and cinnamon.

Commanding the range is RUBY MAE "NANA RUBY" TOLLIVER (66). She looks fifty-five, wears a church-lady apron over pearls, and holds a spatula like a scepter.

At the island are two young women, surrounded by laptops, notebooks, and a hundred tiny glass sample jars:

GRACE BULLOCK (20), a pop star in a hoodie with no makeup who is still stupidly radiant. Her face is on a platinum album cover taped to the fridge, with "Crown Me" in gold.

MALLORY OLSON (19), polished even at breakfast in a blowout and cashmere, highlighting a spreadsheet with military precision.

MALLORY

If we pitch Great-Grandma on Thursday, we need three things. A name, a business plan, and a sample she can't say no to.

NANA RUBY

(not turning around)
Y'all have been saying Grace and Glory since Thanksgiving. Stop fighting over the name and fight over the recipe.

MALLORY

Nana Ruby's right. Great-Grandma Simone won't hand over her 1935 formulas for "vibes."

GRACE

She'll hand them over for me. I'm the baby's baby.

NANA RUBY

Everybody in this family thinks they're the baby's baby. I've been cooking for this family twenty-five years. There's only one baby's baby.

GRACE

Who?

NANA RUBY

(flipping a pancake perfectly)

Me.

The back door opens and ROBERT BULLOCK (45) sweeps in. He looks thirty-eight. Navy Brioni suit, a cashmere scarf, a briefcase, and a BlackBerry in his hand. He moves like he's never been nervous in his life.

He steals a strip of bacon straight off Nana Ruby's plate.

ROBERT
(kisses Grace on the
head)
Morning, superstar.
(kisses Mallory on the
head)
Morning, other superstar.

GRACE
Daddy's going to court.

ROBERT
Daddy's going to WIN in court.
There's a difference.

He checks his BlackBerry. His thumb pauses on a message. He reads it, then pockets the phone a little too quickly.

Nana Ruby notices. She notices everything.

MALLORY
Are you going to the Smilley
ribbon-cutting?

ROBERT
(laughs)
Sweetheart, Lucius Smilley once
tried to hire me. In 1994. A tax
matter.

GRACE
What happened?

ROBERT
I charged him double to say no.
(heading for the door)
Your mother's already up at the
Tower with your grandfather. If
anybody asks, I'm in a deposition
till seven.

NANA RUBY
Dinner's at the Manor at seven.

ROBERT

Then my deposition ends at six
fifty-nine.

He's gone. Grace looks at Nana Ruby.

GRACE

What was that face?

NANA RUBY

What face?

GRACE

You made a face when Daddy
checked his phone.

NANA RUBY

(turning back to the
stove)

I've got one face, baby. God only
issued me the one. Eat your
pancakes.

Grace and Mallory exchange a look.

CUT TO:

**6 INT. SMILLEY TOWER — 72ND FLOOR — CHAIRMAN'S SUITE —
MORNING**

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 9:16 AM EST

Silver, glass, and white orchids. It's all art deco
sleekness where the Donohues have mahogany. A full wall of
windows looks directly across Peachtree at Donohue Tower's
gold crown.

LUCIUS SMILLEY (55), who looks forty-five, stands at the
glass in a flawless dove-gray suit. He leans on a
silver-headed walking cane that he insists is "for style."

Around him, the family:

VIVIENNE SMILLEY (49), who looks thirty-five. A former
runway queen, with icy elegance in a white Chanel suit.
She's adjusting the orchids so they face the window.

DESMOND SMILLEY (48), Lucius's younger brother. Handsome
with an easy laugh and dead eyes. He pours coffee for
everyone and drinks none of it.

LUKE SMILLEY (28), the eldest son, broad-shouldered and
restless. He looks like the heir apparent and isn't one.

He's reading press materials with his jaw clenched.

DELPHINE SMILLEY-ASHE (25). Ice in couture. She's filing her nails with enough force to hurt someone.

LUCIUS

(to the window)

Look at it. Eighty-eight stories.
My father used to say Alexander
Donohue built tall because he was
short.

DESMOND

Daddy said a lot of things about
Alexander Donohue.

LUCIUS

All of them true.

The doors open.

ESTHER enters with a twin on each hand and Bea two steps behind.

ESTHER

Good morning, family.

The mood in the room SHIFTS. Luke stiffens. Delphine smiles like a knife. Desmond is warm, and fake. Vivienne kisses the air near her daughter's cheek. Lucius's face opens up. She is plainly his favorite.

LUCIUS

You're late.

ESTHER

I'm fifteen minutes late. You
told Crowe nine so I'd get here
at nine-fifteen.

LUCIUS

(to the room)

She's the only one of you who
knows how I think.

LUKE

She's the only one of us you TELL
how you think.

VIVIENNE

Lucius Junior.

LUKE

Mother.

Victoria breaks free and runs straight to the window. She presses her face and both palms against the glass, staring at the gold crown across the road.

VICTORIA

Mommy! A crown!

DESMOND

(crouching beside her,
charming)

That's right, sweetheart. That building belongs to some very old friends of ours.

VICTORIA

Can I have it?

DESMOND

(glancing up at Lucius
with a smile)

Ask your granddaddy.

LUCIUS

(to Victoria, gently)

Not today, Dividend. Maybe for your birthday.

The doors open again. Two footmen hold them wide. Everyone stops.

ODESSA HART SMILLEY (84), who looks sixty-five, enters on the arm of an aide. She's in a floor-length white mink with a diamond brooch the size of a doorknob. A retired torch singer, she enters every room as if a spotlight follows her. One does.

ODESSA

Don't everybody get up at once.

Nobody was going to get up. Now EVERYBODY gets up.

She moves to the window. She looks across Peachtree at Donohue Tower's crown for a long, silent moment.

The room goes still. Even Victoria stops squirming.

ODESSA (CONT'D)

(to the building,
almost tender)

Cornelius, baby. We're here.

(beat)
You'd have hated it. Too much
glass. But we're here.

She turns and finds Esther. She takes her granddaughter's
face in both jeweled hands.

ODESSA (CONT'D)
You did this. Built it right
under their noses, the same way
that old snake Alexander bought
his land. Behind a curtain.

ESTHER
I learned from the best, Grandma.

ODESSA
(lowering her voice)
You learned from the enemy.
That's better.

Luke turns away and walks to the bar. Desmond watches him
go, and watches Esther, and files it all away.

LUCIUS
All right. The Mayor's arriving
at nine-fifty. Cameras at ten.
Esther cuts the ribbon.

Lucius turns back to the glass. As he does, his LEFT HAND,
resting on the cane, TREMBLES. It's a fine, fast shaking,
there and gone.

He grips the cane harder and it stops.

Only Vivienne sees it. Her face doesn't change at all. But
she moves to his side and slips her arm through his so
that her hand covers his.

VIVIENNE
(pleasantly, to the
room)
Photos in ten minutes. Everyone
looks rich.

CUT TO:

7 INT. DONOHUE TOWER — DGH BOARDROOM — 88TH FLOOR —
MORNING
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 9:41 AM EST

A boardroom that could double as a cathedral. A forty-foot mahogany table with thirty leather chairs, and the crown logo inlaid in gold in the center. Glass on two sides.

At the foot of the table, where the Chief Executive sits, is Natasha. At the head, the Chairman: Victor. Around them sit TWENTY-EIGHT DGH SENIOR EXECUTIVES in dark suits with leather folios.

A flat-screen on the wall is muted. It shows WBKG's live pre-coverage of the Smilley ribbon-cutting.

Standing at the screen, clicking through a PowerPoint, is MARTIN OLSON (23). He's handsome, precise, and immaculate in a charcoal three-piece suit. His voice is calm and his eyes are calmer. There's something too still about him, like a pond with no fish in it.

MARTIN

—which means Smilley Estates has quietly acquired options on nine parcels between Freedom Parkway and Auburn Avenue since October. All through shell companies. All within two blocks of the original Hotel Donohue.

He clicks. A map of SWEET AUBURN, with red dots clustered around a building marked HOTEL DONOHUE (1936).

NATASHA

They're circling Granddaddy's street.

MARTIN

They're circling something bigger. My sources at City Hall say the Mayor's office is preparing an announcement. Something about a "revival" of Sweet Auburn. Billions of dollars.

VICTOR

(quiet)
Which sources?

MARTIN

(smooth)
The kind that like me, Granddaddy.

VICTOR

That must be a small group.

A few executives smother smiles. Martin's smile doesn't move at all.

The boardroom doors BANG open.

Marc bursts in, balancing FOUR boxes of Krispy Kreme doughnuts stacked to his chin. His tie is perfect. Simone's work.

MARC

Good morning, Donohue Global Holdings! I brought carbohydrates and apologies, mostly carbohydrates!

The room brightens. Executives actually LAUGH. A few reach for the boxes as Marc drops them in the center of the table like a Santa who took a wrong turn.

NATASHA

(trying not to smile)
You're forty minutes late.

MARC

I was at breakfast with the most beautiful woman in Georgia.

NATASHA

Your great-grandmother.

MARC

Don't make it weird, Mama.

He takes a seat against the wall, the observer's seat, not at the table. He's the Heir Apparent, and he sits in a folding-chair position by design.

Martin hasn't moved.

MARTIN

(pleasantly)
Welcome, Marc. We were discussing the survival of the company.

MARC

Cool, cool. How's it going?

MARTIN

The Smilleys are moving on Auburn Avenue.

I'm recommending we move first.
Acquire the remaining parcels on
the 400 block before City Hall
announces anything. Quietly.

VICTOR
We already own the 400 block.

MARTIN
We own the Hotel Donohue
building—

VICTOR
We own the block.
(beat)
Your great-grandfather bought
thirty-one properties on that
street between 1930 and 1933. We
never sold one.

Silence. Martin didn't know that. He should have known
that.

MARC
(casually, mouth full
of doughnut)
Thirty-one. Four on the 300
block, nineteen on the 400 block,
eight around the corner on Bell
Street. I did a report on it in
the fourth grade.

Martin looks at Marc. The dislike in his eyes is brief,
and it is ENORMOUS.

NATASHA
(briskly)
Martin, pull the deeds. Real
Estate Legal, today. I want every
parcel's title in my hand by
Friday.

MARTIN
Of course.

On the TV screen, the WBKG shot pans to the plaza across
the street. A crowd, a red ribbon, and a black limousine
arriving.

NATASHA
Turn it up. The Mayor's here.

An executive unmutes it. Victor stands and walks to the window instead, looking down at the real thing.

Martin sits down, his face perfectly pleasant. Under the table, his thumb slowly presses into the point of a pen until it breaks the skin.

He doesn't flinch.

FADE OUT.

ACT TWO

8 EXT. SMILLEY TOWER — PLAZA — PEACHTREE ROAD — DAY
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 10:02 AM EST

A white stage. A platinum ribbon stretched between two silver pillars. Three hundred invited guests in furs and camel coats. News vans line the curb: WBKG, CNN, and the local affiliates.

A brass quartet plays Duke Ellington. Odessa insisted.

In front of the WBKG camera, microphone in hand, stands CELESTE VAUGHN (24). She's gorgeous, sharp-eyed, and hungry, in a red coat that reads great on television.

CELESTE

(to camera)

—and in a city that has always
had one royal family, this
morning Atlanta has two. The
Smilleys of Chicago, America's
second-wealthiest family, are
officially planting their flag
right here on Peachtree Road,
directly across from the Donohue
empire.

(she glances pointedly
up at Donohue Tower)

On stage, MAYOR JOSEPHINE "JO" WHITAKER (55), who looks forty-five, stands at the podium in a chic navy suit. She's a politician to the marrow, smiling at everyone at once.

MAYOR WHITAKER

—Atlanta has always been a city
too busy to hate. And this
morning, I'd say we're a city too
busy to choose.

Polite laughter. Across the road, she knows she's being watched. Unable to stop herself, she looks up at Donohue Tower and gives a tiny, awkward WAVE toward the 88th floor.

MAYOR WHITAKER (CONT'D)

(recovering)

Ladies and gentlemen, Mr. Lucius
Smilley.

Lucius takes the podium to warm applause, leaning on his cane with great elegance.

LUCIUS

Thank you, Madam Mayor.

He surveys the crowd. He's a natural showman, his father's son.

LUCIUS (CONT'D)

In 1926, my father, Cornelius Smilley, was a Pullman porter on the Dixie Flyer. Chicago to Jacksonville. Every run, the train stopped in Atlanta. And every run, my father looked out the window at this city and was not allowed to get off.

(beat)

They let him carry the bags. They didn't let him sleep here.

The crowd grows quiet.

LUCIUS (CONT'D)

Seventy-nine years later, his family doesn't just get off the train.

(he gestures up at the tower)

We brought the station.

APPLAUSE. Real applause this time.

LUCIUS (CONT'D)

And my daughter built it. Esther.

Esther steps forward with the gold scissors in her hand. Flashbulbs erupt. She is devastating on camera, and she knows exactly how to stand in the light.

Behind her, the family watches: Odessa radiant, Vivienne gracious, Desmond applauding, Luke applauding slowly, Delphine not applauding at all.

Esther cuts the ribbon. It falls. The brass quartet swells. Balloons are released: silver, hundreds of them, rising past the glass.

At the back of the crowd, a sleek black Escalade screeches to the curb, badly parked. QUENTIN SMILLEY (21) climbs out of the back seat in last night's velvet blazer and giant sunglasses, carrying a coffee.

QUENTIN
(to nobody)
Did I miss it?

A SMILLEY AIDE
The ribbon's cut, Mr. Smilley.

QUENTIN
Great. Perfect timing. I hate
ribbons.

Desmond, his father, catches his eye from the stage. It's a look that could strip paint. Quentin raises the coffee like a toast.

The PRESS surges toward the stage rope. Esther steps down to take questions, flanked by Crowe.

REPORTER #2
Is this a declaration of war on
the Donohue family?

ESTHER
(the smallest smile)
I don't declare war. I declare
dividends.

Laughter. She's winning the room.

CELESTE
(pushing to the front)
Celeste Vaughn, WBKG. Miss
Smilley, you're twenty-two,
you're running a company worth
more than most nations, and
you're raising twin daughters
alone. People are still curious
about the decision you made in
2001.

The laughter dies. Esther's eyes go cold behind the smile.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
The donor. Do you ever plan to
tell your daughters who their
father—

ESTHER
My daughters have a father, Miss
Vaughn.

A beat.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
He's called "science." He's very handsome, very quiet, and he never leaves the toilet seat up.

The crowd ROARS with laughter. The moment is saved.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
Next question.

But as she turns, her hand is pressed flat against her thigh to keep it from shaking.

On the far side of the stage, Bea stands with the twins in their matching white coats. Victoria waves to the cameras like a queen.

CELESTE
(to her cameraman, low)
Did you get her hand?

CAMERAMAN
Got it.

CELESTE
(smiling)
Good girl.

CUT TO:

9 INT. CITY HALL EAST — APD HEADQUARTERS — PRESS ROOM — DAY
Monday, January 3, 2005 — 11:02 AM EST

675 Ponce de Leon Avenue. A cramped press room with fluorescent lights. The APD shield hangs behind a podium. Two American flags and a Georgia flag.

Forty reporters and eight cameras. This is the most crowded APD press conference in years.

At the podium in dress blues, with four gold stars on each collar, is CHIEF ELXA BULLOCK JACKSON (24). She looks younger, and she's spent her entire career making people regret noticing that. Her posture is a ruler.

Behind her stand the command staff, and at their center DEPUTY CHIEF WARREN HUGHES (46), a gray-mustached veteran whose smile never reaches his eyes.

Against the back wall, arms folded, in a rumpled sport coat, is DETECTIVE JEREMY JACKSON (24). Square-jawed,

earnest, an Eagle Scout grown up. He is watching his wife with pure pride.

ELXA

—so my 2005 priorities are simple. Homicide clearance. Response times. And cleaning up the evidence room, which, frankly, looks like my brother's closet.

A little laughter. She doesn't smile. She wasn't joking.

ELXA (CONT'D)

And second, the organized criminal enterprise known as the Blackwater Syndicate.

The room sharpens. Pens up.

ELXA (CONT'D)

On December 20th, I announced a dedicated task force. As of this morning, it is staffed, funded, and operational. We will find out who "Sovereign" is, and we will put him in a cell.

(beat)

Questions.

A DOZEN HANDS.

REPORTER #1

Chief, you're twenty-four years old—

ELXA

I'm aware of my birthday, thank you.

REPORTER #1

—the youngest police chief of a major city in American history. Your father-in-law is the chief who retired. Your grandfather is Victor Donohue. How do you respond to people calling you the "Nepotism Chief"?

The room holds its breath. Behind her, Hughes looks at the floor, fighting a smile.

ELXA

I respond with my record.

(evenly)

Two hundred and twelve homicide investigations as lead or supervising detective. A ninety-one percent clearance rate. The Peachtree Strangler, three years unsolved before I took it and closed in eleven weeks. I've been shot at twice. I've never been late to a crime scene. I've never been bought.

(beat)

If my family got me this job, they owe me an apology for making me work so hard for it.

A murmur. It's good. Jeremy grins at the back wall.

REPORTER #2

Chief, some people in this city see Sovereign as a hero. His charity arm paid off the medical debt of the entire pediatric ward at Grady last month—

ELXA

Sovereign is a criminal.

REPORTER #2

—they call him Atlanta's Robin Hood—

ELXA

Robin Hood was a criminal, too. He just had a better publicist.

(beat)

Nobody in this city gets to decide which laws apply to him because he's generous. Not Sovereign. Not my family. Not me.

She steps back from the podium.

ELXA (CONT'D)

Thank you.

The cameras flash. She walks off.

Hughes falls into step beside her in the hallway.

HUGHES
Strong stuff, Chief. "Not my
family." They'll love that.

ELXA
Who's "they," Warren?

HUGHES
(pleasantly)
Everybody watching.

ELXA
Then everybody watching can see
you smiling during the nepotism
question. Maybe don't, next time.

She keeps walking. Hughes stops, his smile gone.

Jeremy catches up to her at the elevator.

JEREMY
(quietly, so no one
else hears)
"If my family got me this job,
they owe me an apology."

ELXA
Too much?

JEREMY
It was perfect. I'm going to have
it embroidered on a pillow.

ELXA
(the elevator opens)
Get back to work, Detective.

JEREMY
Yes, Chief.
(as the doors close,
softer)
Love you.

ELXA
(doors closing, not
looking at him,
smiling)
I know.

CUT TO:

**10 INT. CHILDREN'S HEALTHCARE OF ATLANTA AT EGLESTON –
PEDIATRIC ONCOLOGY PLAYROOM – DAY**

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 11:43 AM EST

A bright, cheerful room fighting hard against the reason it exists. Murals of animals. Beanbags. IV poles decorated with tinsel left over from Christmas.

A dozen KIDS, ages four to twelve, some bald, some in wheelchairs, some attached to monitors, are gathered in a semicircle on the floor.

In the middle, sitting cross-legged in his very expensive suit on a carpet stained with finger paint, is Marc. He has a picture book in one hand and a paper crown on his head.

MARC
(in a deep, rumbling
monster voice)
"And the wild things roared their
terrible roars, and gnashed their
terrible teeth—"

He GNASHES at the kids. They SHRIEK with joy.

MARC (CONT'D)
"—and rolled their terrible
eyes—"

He rolls his eyes so far back that DEANDRE (9), a bald boy in a Falcons jersey, laughs so hard he falls off his beanbag.

KEYONNA
(7, tiny, in a pink
headscarf, right in
front)
You ARE in a hospital.

He finishes the page with a flourish. Then he closes the book.

MARC (CONT'D)
And that's where we stop.

The kids GROAN.

MARC (CONT'D)
I know. I know. But if I finish
it today, I don't have a reason
to come back Thursday.

KEYONNA
You'd come back anyway.

MARC
(soft)
Yeah. I would.

He adjusts the paper crown on his head.

KEYONNA
Do you have kids?

MARC
Not yet.

KEYONNA
Why not?

MARC
Because I haven't found their
mama yet. That's the order it
goes in. First the mama, then the
kids, then the minivan, then you
lose your mind.

DEANDRE
How many are you gonna have?

MARC
(thinking seriously)
Enough for a basketball team.
With subs.

DEANDRE
That's like twelve!

MARC
Twelve's a good start.

The kids laugh. NURSE TONYA, a warm, heavyset woman in
cartoon scrubs, leans in the doorway, smiling.

NURSE TONYA
Mr. Bullock, your phone's been
buzzing in my pocket for ten
minutes. You told me to hold it
so you wouldn't be rude.

MARC
And I appreciate your service,
Miss Tonya.
(to the kids)

Nobody move. Guard the wild things.

He steps into the hallway. His whole demeanor shifts in one step: the playfulness drains away and something harder takes its place.

INT. EGLESTON — HALLWAY — CONTINUOUS

He takes the satellite phone from Nurse Tonya.

MARC
(into phone)
Talk to me.

INTERCUT WITH:

**EXT. SOUTHERN SRI LANKA — COLLAPSED COASTAL ROAD — NIGHT
(10:43 PM LOCAL)**

Roman stands beside a BSI truck at the edge of a road that simply ends, washed out into the sea.

ROMAN
There's a fishing village south of Galle we couldn't reach. The road's gone. Three hundred people. The locals say there's a clinic, but no medicine's gotten in since the twenty-sixth.

MARC
Helicopters?

ROMAN
Two. But the government's saying we need clearance through the ministry. Could take three days.

Marc closes his eyes for exactly one second.

MARC
Roman. Do those people have three days?

ROMAN
No.

MARC
Then we don't have three days either.

(beat)
Fly in. Land at the clinic.
Unload the medicine. If anybody
from the ministry complains, tell
them Blackwater Security
International will be happy to
fill out every form they have.
After.
Rules are for keeping people
safe, Roman. When the rules are
the thing getting people killed,
the rules can wait in the lobby.

A long beat. Roman nods to someone off-screen and makes a
circling motion. Rotors start whining up.

ROMAN
Wheels up in six minutes.

END INTERCUT.

Marc hangs up. He stands alone in the hospital corridor
for a moment, looking at the phone.

Through the playroom door's glass window he can see
Keyonna, waiting. She's sitting perfectly still so she
doesn't "move," like he told her.

He takes a breath, puts the smile back on like a jacket,
and pushes the door open.

MARC (CONT'D)
(big monster voice)
WHO MOVED?

The kids SCREAM with delight.

FADE OUT.

ACT THREE**11 INT. FULTON COUNTY COURTHOUSE – DISTRICT ATTORNEY'S OFFICE – DAY**

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 12:21 PM EST

136 Pryor Street. A corner office with government carpet and a stunning view of downtown. It's half moved-in: boxes, a new nameplate still in bubble wrap.

TWO WORKMEN are taking down an oil PORTRAIT of former District Attorney LAWRENCE TATE, a jowly, dignified man in a three-piece suit.

Watching from behind a very large desk that doesn't yet feel like hers is DISTRICT ATTORNEY ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22). She's striking and precise, in a black St. John suit with a strand of pearls. She's brilliant and she's scared, and she knows how to hide the second one.

Across the desk, a harried deputy with a stack of files: ASSISTANT DA PRESTON (40s).

PRESTON

—which brings us to the cold case unit. Your predecessor, uh—

(glances at the
portrait going out the
door)

—reassigned it to white-collar in 2003. It's two investigators and a closet.

ARIANNA

How many open cases?

PRESTON

Six hundred and forty.

ARIANNA

(standing)

Restaff it. Four investigators, a victim liaison, and a real office. Not a closet. I want every family who's been waiting to get a phone call by the end of the month.

PRESTON

Every family? Ma'am, that's—

ARIANNA
That's the job, Preston.

He nods, scribbling, and exits.

The workmen carry out Tate's portrait. Arianna watches it go. For a moment she's alone.

She picks up her nameplate and slowly unwraps it: DISTRICT ATTORNEY ARIANNA L. CUMMINGS. She sets it on the desk. She adjusts it a quarter-inch.

She picks up her coffee and walks out.

**INT. FULTON COUNTY COURTHOUSE – 3RD FLOOR HALLWAY –
CONTINUOUS**

A long, busy hallway with lawyers, clerks, and families on benches. Along the wall runs a COMMUNITY BULLETIN BOARD crowded with flyers: lost dogs, legal aid, a gospel concert.

Arianna walks past it, sipping coffee, then STOPS.

In the center of the board, freshly stapled, is a bright yellow flyer with a photograph of a smiling young man in a barber's smock. DARNELL "DEE" DIVINE.

INSERT – THE FLYER: "HAVE YOU SEEN DEE? DARNELL DIVINE – MISSING SINCE NEW YEAR'S EVE 2001. LAST SEEN NEAR NORTHSIDE DRIVE. 5'11", 170 LBS. BARBER. SON. BROTHER. PLEASE CALL. \$50,000 REWARD." Below it, a phone number and a web address: "FINDDEE.LIVEJOURNAL.COM."

Arianna stands perfectly still. The hallway's noise seems to fall away.

Her hand, holding the coffee, begins to tremble. She sets the cup down on a windowsill very carefully.

She reaches out and touches the edge of the flyer with one finger, as if it might be hot.

A passing CLERK smiles at her.

CLERK
Morning, Madam District Attorney!

ARIANNA
(instant, flawless
smile)
Good morning.

The clerk moves on. The smile vanishes like a light switched off.

She pulls out her flip phone, a silver RAZR, and dials a number from memory.

INTERCUT WITH:

**INT. MARC'S ASTON MARTIN – MOVING – CLIFTON ROAD –
CONTINUOUS**

Marc drives one-handed, talking on a Bluetooth earpiece. The paper crown from Eggleston is still on the passenger seat.

MARC
Madam District Attorney. How's
the view from the top?

ARIANNA
(quiet)
I just needed to hear a friendly
voice.

A beat. Marc's face changes instantly. He knows her too well.

MARC
Where are you?

ARIANNA
Third floor.

MARC
What happened?

ARIANNA
Nothing. It's nothing. It's...
(she looks at the
flyer)
They're everywhere, Marc.

Marc doesn't ask what "they" are. His jaw tightens.

MARC
Okay. Listen to me.
(calm, steady, the
voice he uses with
frightened kids)
You're going to walk back to your
office. You're going to close the
door. You're going to eat the

lunch your mother packed you—

ARIANNA
(a small, wet laugh)
How do you know she packed me
lunch?

MARC
Because it's your first day, and
Dr. Yvette Cummings still thinks
you're nine. Turkey on wheat, cut
diagonally, apple slices with
lemon on them so they don't
brown.

ARIANNA
(almost smiling)
...And a note.

MARC
What's the note say?

ARIANNA
"Proud of you. Eat the apple."

MARC
Then eat the apple, Ari.
(beat)
You're the DA. You earned that
office. Walk into it like you own
it, because you do.

A long beat. She takes a breath and stands a little
straighter.

ARIANNA
Okay.

MARC
Okay?

ARIANNA
Okay.

MARC
I love you. Eat the apple.

She hangs up.

END INTERCUT.

INT. FULTON COUNTY COURTHOUSE – HALLWAY – CONTINUOUS

Arianna picks up her coffee. She walks back toward her office without looking at the flyer again.

Behind her, Darnell Divine smiles from the board.

CUT TO:

12 EXT. PEACHTREE ROAD – NEAR LENOX STATION – DAY

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 12:47 PM EST

Lunch-hour Buckhead: office workers, shoppers, and traffic. On a light pole near the MARTA station entrance, a young woman is stapling a yellow flyer. The same one.

HARMONY DIVINE (22). Pretty, bright-eyed, and exhausted, in a practical wool coat and knockoff Coach boots. She has a stack of a hundred more flyers under her arm and a staple gun in her hand. She moves with the rhythm of someone who has done this every week for three years.

Beside her, bundled in a stroller like a small purple burrito, is LYRIC SOLACE BAKER (2). She's angelic, singing softly to a stuffed giraffe.

LYRIC

(singing)

Twinkle twinkle, little Dee...

Harmony freezes, then smiles through it.

HARMONY

That's right, baby. Little Dee.

She staples. Chunk. Chunk.

A glossy black RANGE ROVER stops at the red light right beside her.

The driver's window is down: Amond. He's on his way somewhere important and looking at her.

They see each other. The silence is enormous.

Lyric notices first.

LYRIC

(delighted)

DADDY!

AMOND
(unable to stop the
smile)
Hey, Lyric-bird.

LYRIC
Daddy, I'm singing!

AMOND
I heard. You sound like a star.
Harmony doesn't look at him. She keeps stapling.

AMOND (CONT'D)
(to Harmony)
You need a ride? It's cold.

HARMONY
I have a car.

AMOND
Where?

HARMONY
It's parked. Somewhere. Near
things.

AMOND
Harmony—

HARMONY
(finally turning)
What I need, Amond, is for you to
read the schedule your lawyer
sent to my lawyer, because your
mother apparently thinks she gets
Lyric on Sundays now, and nobody
asked me.

AMOND
My mother—
(stops)
What?

HARMONY
Exactly.

The light turns green. Cars HONK behind him.

AMOND
I'll call you.

HARMONY

Call my lawyer. Like a grown-up.

He hesitates. The honking gets louder. He looks at Lyric one more time.

AMOND

Bye, Lyric-bird.

LYRIC

Bye, Daddy! Bye!

He drives off. Lyric waves at the Range Rover until it's gone.

Harmony stands there with the staple gun, breathing.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

Mommy, is Daddy coming back?

HARMONY

(crouching, fixing her
hat)

Daddy always comes back, baby.
He's just not good at staying.

She stands and staples one more flyer. Chunk.

CUT TO:

13 INT. RAVENHURST — GRAND HALL — DAY

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 1:44 PM EST

A 1920s French château transplanted into Buckhead. It's colossal: a double staircase, a black-and-white marble floor, and a crystal chandelier the size of a car. Movers are still unwrapping furniture everywhere, and priceless art leans against the walls.

Esther, in jeans and a cashmere sweater now, has her shoes off and her hair up, directing movers with a clipboard.

ESTHER

No. The Basquiat goes in the
library. The Picasso goes in the
powder room.

MOVER

The powder room?

ESTHER

My grandmother hates Picasso.
She'll see it every time she
powders her nose, and it'll keep
her young.

The front door swings open. Crowe steps aside.

HARMONY (O.S.)

Please tell me there's a Picasso
in the bathroom!

Esther SPINS.

Harmony stands in the doorway with Lyric on her hip and a
bottle of cheap champagne in her other hand.

For one second, Esther is absolutely still. Then the ice
queen is gone and she is twenty-two years old.

ESTHER

HARMONY!

HARMONY

ESTHER!

They run at each other, SCREAMING, across the marble
floor, and crash into a hug. Lyric is squashed in the
middle and giggling. The movers stop and stare.

Esther laughs, a real laugh, completely unguarded. She
pulls back to look at Lyric.

ESTHER

Oh my God. Lyric Solace Baker.
You got so BIG.

Footsteps pound on the grand staircase. The twins come
barreling down: Victoria on her backside, sliding step to
step; Emma walking properly and holding the rail, with Bea
hurrying behind.

VICTORIA

LYRIC!

LYRIC

TORI! EMMIE!

Lyric wriggles down and the three little girls COLLIDE in
a squealing pile at the foot of the stairs. They've
clearly known each other all their lives.

BEA
(arriving, out of
breath)
Miss Divine. How lovely.

HARMONY
Hi, Bea! Did you miss me?

BEA
Desperately.

Harmony and Esther watch them. Two best friends, and three babies who were born within three weeks of each other.

HARMONY
Look at them.

ESTHER
I know.

HARMONY
Like sisters.

ESTHER
(a flicker of
something)
...Like sisters.

Harmony pops the cheap champagne. It foams all over the priceless marble. Neither of them cares. Esther grabs two Baccarat flutes off a mover's cart.

They clink flutes. Harmony looks around at the château.

HARMONY
Girl. This is a whole castle.
(softer)
Dee would've loved this. He'd
have been sliding down that
banister in his socks before you
got the door closed.

Esther sobers. She takes Harmony's hand.

ESTHER
Three years this past Saturday.

HARMONY
Three years. New Year's Day.
(beat)
Mama wouldn't get out of bed.
Daddy drove his bus route anyway.
He said if Dee comes home, he'll

probably take the 71.

ESTHER

Harm.

HARMONY

I put up four hundred flyers this weekend. I'm going to the new DA this week. The girl who just won. They say she's reopening old cases.

ESTHER

Arianna Cummings.

HARMONY

You know her?

ESTHER

I know of her. Everybody in America knows of a twenty-two-year-old DA.

(beat)

I'll make some calls. Whatever you need. Private investigators, whatever.

HARMONY

Esther, I can't afford—

ESTHER

I didn't say you could. I said I'll make some calls.

Harmony squeezes her hand, then shakes it off, too emotional. She changes the subject brightly.

HARMONY

Okay. Enough. Where's the fiancé? When do I finally meet this man?

ESTHER

Sebastian's in London until spring. Closing a deal.

HARMONY

He proposed on Christmas Eve in PARIS and then went back to London?

ESTHER

He's very busy.

HARMONY

Uh-huh.

ESTHER

He's very handsome.

HARMONY

Uh-huh.

ESTHER

He's very... appropriate.

HARMONY

(dead serious)

Esther Odessa Smilley.

"Appropriate" is what you call a pair of shoes.

Esther laughs and throws a napkin at her.

HARMONY (CONT'D)

Oh! And you HAVE to meet Lyric's godfather. He lives right over there, like, two hundred yards through those trees.

(points out the window,
toward the ravine)

Marc-Anthony Bullock. He's the sweetest man alive, I swear to God. He brought Lyric a pony for Christmas. A real pony. I live in a townhouse, Esther.

Esther's glass stops halfway to her mouth. A beat too long.

ESTHER

(carefully casual)

The Donohue heir.

HARMONY

Yeah! You'd love him. He's hilarious. Like, disgusting-hilarious. He does this thing where—

ESTHER

We're competitors, Harm.

HARMONY

So? You're competitors with everybody.

ESTHER
(sets her glass down)
The families don't mix. It's a whole thing. It's been a whole thing since before we were born.

HARMONY
That's so stupid.

ESTHER
(too quickly)
It is what it is.

On the rug, Victoria has climbed onto Lyric's back and is "riding" her like a pony.

VICTORIA
GIDDY UP! Pony Marc!

Esther turns sharply.

ESTHER
What did she say?

HARMONY
(laughing)
Lyric's been telling everybody about her pony. It's named Marc. After her godfather. She's obsessed.

Esther stares at her daughter, riding a toddler named after the pony named after the man.

ESTHER
(faint)
Of course it is.

CUT TO:

14 INT. BSI TOWER – MARC'S OFFICE – 58TH FLOOR – DAY
Monday, January 3, 2005 – 2:48 PM EST

Midtown. A penthouse office of black glass and steel. It's the opposite of Donohue Tower: modern, sleek, a little dangerous. One whole wall is monitors, showing BSI operations worldwide: Sri Lanka, Indonesia, the Port of Savannah, a stadium in Houston.

Marc sits with his feet on the desk, eating cold Chinese food out of the carton.

Across from him, Amond scrolls through a legal document on a BlackBerry, radiating fury.

Pacing between them with a clipboard and three phones is BRIELLE SUTTON (21), Marc's executive assistant. She's hyper-organized, very funny, and in a Spelman sweatshirt under a blazer.

BRIELLE

The Smilleys got a courtesy invitation to your birthday from the DGH protocol office.

Marc chokes on a noodle.

MARC

They WHAT?

BRIELLE

It's automatic. New neighbors bordering Belmont Crest get invited to family events within their first month. It's in the 1961 bylaws. Your great-grandmother wrote them.

MARC

(wiping his mouth)
Gorgeous invited the Smilleys to my birthday.

BRIELLE

Technically, Gorgeous invited the Smilleys to your birthday forty-four years ago.

MARC

(delighted)
She's evil. I love her so much.

Brielle's desk phone rings. She answers, walks away, still talking.

Marc looks at Amond, who hasn't said a word.

MARC (CONT'D)

Okay. What?

AMOND

Nothing.

MARC

You've been reading the same email for eleven minutes. Your face is doing the thing.

AMOND

My mother filed a petition.

MARC

For what?

AMOND

Grandparent visitation. With Lyric. Sundays.

(tossing the BlackBerry on the desk)

She didn't tell me. Harmony found out before I did. I saw her on Peachtree an hour ago, stapling flyers with my daughter in a stroller, and she looked at me like I'd done it.

MARC

Did you?

AMOND

Of course not!

MARC

Then tell her that.

AMOND

She won't let me tell her anything. We've talked more through lawyers than we ever talked in person. We talked in person for one night, Marc. One night. Three years ago.

MARC

And you made a whole person. So you must've been talking about something.

AMOND

(despite himself, a laugh)

Man, shut up.

Marc swings his feet off the desk and leans forward.

MARC
Call your mother. Then call
Harmony. Not her lawyer. Her.

AMOND
She hates me.

MARC
She doesn't hate you. She's
scared of you. That's different.
It just looks the same from the
outside.

Amond looks at him. Marc says things like this without
warning.

Amond picks up the BlackBerry again. He hesitates, then
looks back at Marc.

AMOND
Can I ask you something?

MARC
You're going to anyway.

AMOND
Do you still think about her?

Marc doesn't need to ask who.

He sets the carton down. He leans back in his chair and
looks out at the gray January sky over Midtown.

MARC
Every day.

AMOND
It was one night. A masquerade.
You don't know her name. You
don't know her face.

MARC
I know her laugh.
(beat)
She laughed at a joke I made
about the host's toupee. Nobody
else laughed. It was a bad joke.
She laughed like it was the
funniest thing she'd ever heard,
and then she looked embarrassed
for laughing, and then she
laughed harder.
(quiet)

Gold mask. Smelled like jasmine.
And in the morning she was gone.
No note. No name.

AMOND
Three and a half years.

MARC
Three years, four months, and two
days.

AMOND
(softly)
That's crazy, bro.

MARC
I know.
(he smiles, a little
sadly)
But I'll know it when I hear it
again. That laugh. I'll know it
anywhere.

Brielle swings back in, phones in both hands.

BRIELLE
Sri Lanka on line one. Roman says
the helicopters landed. The
clinic got the medicine. Three
hundred people. And the ministry
is "very upset."

Marc stands, grinning, the sadness gone as fast as it
came.

MARC
Tell the ministry I'm sending
them a fruit basket. The BIG one.
(grabbing the phone)
Roman! My guy!

Amond watches his best friend laugh into the phone. Then
he looks down at his BlackBerry, at Harmony's name in his
contacts.

He doesn't call. Not yet.

FADE OUT.

ACT FOUR**15 INT. RAVENHURST — THE LIBRARY — DUSK**

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 5:06 PM EST

A two-story library with rolling ladders and a stone fireplace crackling. The Basquiat has been hung over the mantel, a jolt of electric color in a room of leather and mahogany.

Esther curls in a wingback chair in socks, reviewing contracts with a red pen. The twins sprawl on the rug in their pajamas, coloring. Bea knits in the corner. A television on a side table plays WBKG with the volume low.

WBKG ANCHOR (ON TV)
—and in lighter news, Atlanta's
most eligible bachelor turns
twenty-three this week.

Esther doesn't look up. Then she does.

On the screen: Marc, filmed this morning outside Egleston, still wearing the paper crown, laughing with his head thrown back, a sick child on his shoulders.

WBKG ANCHOR (ON TV) (CONT'D)
Marc-Anthony Bullock, the Donohue
heir and founder of Blackwater
Security International, spent his
morning reading to young cancer
patients at Egleston. Asked about
his birthday plans, Bullock told
WBKG:

MARC (ON TV)
(to the camera,
grinning)
I'm gonna eat cake until I pass
out. Then somebody better wake me
up for more cake.

Victoria's head snaps up from her coloring book. She stares at the screen.

VICTORIA
(pointing, delighted)
FUNNY MAN!

Emma looks up too. She studies the screen with the same solemn focus she gives to her books.

EMMA

He has a crown.

VICTORIA

FUNNY MAN HAS A CROWN!

On screen, Marc laughs again, head thrown back.

At the exact same moment, Victoria throws her head back and laughs. It's the same laugh, the same angle, the same sound. It's uncanny.

Esther stops breathing.

Bea's knitting needles go still.

Esther rises and walks to the television. Very calmly, very quickly, she switches it off.

The screen goes black. The only sound is the fire.

VICTORIA

(outraged)

MOMMY! The funny man!

ESTHER

(too bright)

It's bedtime, Dividend.

VICTORIA

It's not dark!

ESTHER

(scooping her up)

It's dark somewhere, baby.

BEA

(quietly, setting her
knitting aside)

I'll take them up, Miss Smilley.

ESTHER

(handing Victoria over)

Thank you, Bea.

(beat)

And Bea. We don't watch the local news in this house.

BEA

(evenly)

Of course.

Bea takes the twins by the hands and leads them out. As they go, Victoria looks back over her shoulder at the dead black screen.

VICTORIA
(whispering, to Emma)
Funny man.

EMMA
(whispering back)
Crown.

They're gone.

Esther stands alone in the firelight, staring at her own reflection in the black television screen.

Slowly, she crosses to the window. Through the trees, across the ravine, the lights of Belmont Crest's great houses glitter on the bluff.

She presses her fingertips against the cold glass.

ESTHER
(barely a whisper)
Not yet.

CUT TO:

16 INT. BELLE RIVE – MASTER SUITE – DUSK
Monday, January 3, 2005 – 5:41 PM EST

A bedroom suite fit for Italian royalty: silk walls, a four-poster bed, and a dressing room with a wall of shoes that could stock a boutique.

Natasha sits at a vanity in a slip, fastening diamond earrings. Robert stands behind her in his tuxedo shirt, fighting with his cufflinks.

NATASHA
Your deposition ended early.

ROBERT
The witness broke. They always break at four-thirty. It's the blood sugar.

She holds out her hand without turning. He puts the cufflink in it. She fastens his cuff for him in one smooth motion. Twenty-three years of marriage in one gesture.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Did you see Elxa's press
conference?

NATASHA
Every channel ran it.

ROBERT
"If my family got me this job,
they owe me an apology for making
me work so hard for it."

NATASHA
(smiling)
She was magnificent.

ROBERT
She was reckless.

NATASHA
She's your daughter.

ROBERT
That's what I said.

Natasha meets his eyes in the mirror. A shared look.
Something unspoken between them.

NATASHA
She can never know, Robert.

ROBERT
She won't.

NATASHA
Daddy made two phone calls. You
made one. The Mayor would have
picked her anyway.

ROBERT
(beat)
Probably.

NATASHA
Definitely.

ROBERT
Then why'd we make the calls?

NATASHA
(turning to face him)
Because "probably" is for people
who don't own the building.

He kisses her. It's hungry and familiar. The power couple is still very much in love.

Then his BlackBerry BUZZES on the dresser.

He glances at it. A name flashes: C. RHODES.

He silences it.

ROBERT

Office.

NATASHA

At six o'clock on a Monday?

ROBERT

Crime doesn't take holidays,
baby.

He picks up the phone and walks toward the balcony doors.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

Two minutes.

He steps out onto the balcony and closes the glass door behind him. Through it, Natasha can see him pacing in the cold, talking low, his back to her.

She watches him in the mirror, perfectly still, one earring still in her hand.

She picks up a crystal perfume bottle from her vanity and sprays her wrist. She raises it to her nose, closes her eyes, and inhales.

Then she opens her eyes and fastens the second earring without looking away from her husband's back.

CUT TO:

17 EXT. SOVEREIGN WAY — THE SUMMIT — EVENING

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 6:47 PM EST

Twilight on the Summit. Gas lamps flicker to life along a private lane lined with century oaks. Six great estates glow around a formal garden.

At the far end, DONOHUE MANOR, a white Georgian palace, blazes with light in every window.

Marc and Grace walk up the lane arm in arm, in black tie. Marc is in a perfectly cut tuxedo. Grace is in a vintage

gold gown with a fur stole, and she still walks like a teenager.

They pass the dark hulk of Ashgrove, Theodore's shuttered house. Dead leaves blow across its steps. Grace shivers and pulls her stole tighter.

GRACE (CONT'D)

That house gives me the creeps.

MARC

It's just empty.

GRACE

That's what gives me the creeps.
Empty houses on this street don't
stay empty.

They walk a few steps in silence. Grace's tone changes.

GRACE (CONT'D)

Marc.

MARC

Mm.

GRACE

You know I'd do anything for you.
Right?

MARC

I know, Gracie.

GRACE

No, like... anything.
(beat)
Shovel-level anything.

Marc stops walking. He looks at her in the lamplight, and for a moment he isn't joking at all.

MARC

Let's keep the shovel in the
shed.

GRACE

I'm just saying. It's there.

MARC

(soft)
I know it's there. That's why I'm
never gonna need it.

He kisses the top of her head.

She squeezes his arm. They share a secret neither of them has ever said out loud. July 15, 2000 hangs in the air between them.

Then Grace brightens, deliberately.

GRACE

Also, I'm singing at your party
and I'm charging you.

MARC

How much?

GRACE

One dollar and a kidney.

MARC

Whose kidney?

GRACE

Martin's.

MARC

(delighted)

DEAL.

They walk up the steps of Donohue Manor, laughing, as the great front doors swing open and golden light spills out.

WINSTON FAIRLEY (62), the Manor's Jamaican-born butler, stands in the doorway. He's immaculate, dignified, and silently amused by everything.

WINSTON

Master Marc-Anthony. Miss Grace.
You are four minutes early. Your
grandfather will be suspicious.

MARC

Winston, I've been early exactly
once in my life, and it was an
accident.

WINSTON

(taking their coats)

Then we shall call it a miracle,
sir, and not speak of it again.

FADE OUT.

ACT FIVE

18 INT. DONOHUE MANOR – THE GRAND DINING ROOM – NIGHT
Monday, January 3, 2005 – 7:04 PM EST

A dining room built for kings. A thirty-foot table set for fourteen under three crystal chandeliers. Candlelight. Silver. A portrait of Alexander and Simone from 1936, at the Hotel Donohue's opening, presides from the far wall.

The family is seated. Winston and two footmen serve the soup: she-crab, Simone's recipe.

At the head of the table, Victor. At the foot, THE HONORABLE JOAN MERCER DONOHUE (66), who looks fifty-two. She's regal, warm, and precise, in midnight-blue silk. Around her throat is a triple strand of antique PEARLS.

At Victor's right hand, in the place of honor, is Simone, in black velvet with a diamond clip in her hair.

Along the sides: Jasmine (in navy, for tomorrow's swearing-in), Peter, Martin, Mallory, Natasha, Robert, Grace, and Marc. Two empty chairs are for Elxa and Jeremy.

Simone lifts her spoon and sees Joan's pearls. She pauses and looks at Victor.

SIMONE
(quietly)
The Washington pearls.

VICTOR
Yes, Mother.

SIMONE
(a slow, dangerous smile)
Well. All right, then.

She eats her soup. The adults exchange glances. The young people are baffled.

MALLORY
(whispering to Grace)
What just happened?

GRACE
(whispering back)
I think Granddaddy declared war with jewelry.

JOAN
(not looking up)
I can hear you, girls. I was a
federal judge for twenty-four
years. I can hear a whisper
through a closed courtroom door.

MALLORY
Sorry, Grandma Joan.

JOAN
(smiling)
Don't be sorry. Be quieter.

Laughter. Victor taps his glass. The table quiets.

VICTOR
Before we eat, a toast.
(raising his wine)
To my daughter. Tomorrow at noon,
for the tenth time, the people of
Georgia send Jasmine Donohue
Olson to the Congress of the
United States.
(beat)
Your great-grandfather couldn't
cast a real vote in this state
until he was forty-one years old.
Tomorrow, his granddaughter makes
the laws.

JOAN
Hear, hear.

ALL
To Jasmine!

They drink. Jasmine is moved. Peter squeezes her hand.

JASMINE
Thank you, Daddy.
The main course arrives: rack of
lamb, collard greens, candied
yams, and cornbread in cast-iron
skillets. Donohue Manor serves
soul food on Limoges china.

NATASHA
Alvin called.

JOAN
(bracing)
From where?

NATASHA
Miami.

JOAN
Still.

NATASHA
He sends his love, his
congratulations to Jasmine, and a
case of Cristal.

JOAN
He sends his love. The Cristal
he's billing to the company.

Big laughs. Joan shakes her head, amused and exasperated.

JOAN (CONT'D)
Nine months on a boat. What kind
of man lives on a boat?

Martin smiles politely into his wine.

MARTIN
Speaking of people who don't
call. Did everyone see Esther
Smilley's press conference?

The table cools instantly.

NATASHA
We saw it.

MARTIN
"I don't declare war. I declare
dividends."
(to Marc, lightly)
You'll want to watch out, cousin.
She's your age, and she's already
built a skyscraper. What have you
built?

A beat. Everyone looks at Marc.

MARC
(cheerfully)
A security company in sixty-four
countries, a relief operation in
Sri Lanka, and a very close
personal relationship with every
child at Egleston. What have YOU
built, Martin?

MARTIN

A PowerPoint.

MARC

(genuinely warm)

It was a really good PowerPoint,
man. The fonts were crazy.
Gorgeous fonts.

Laughter, even from Jasmine. Martin laughs too, perfectly,
at exactly the right volume.

Peter doesn't laugh. He watches his son's hand. Under the
table, Martin's fingers are pressing into his napkin until
the knuckles go gray.

The doors open. Elxa and Jeremy hurry in, Elxa still in
her dress blues and Jeremy in a sport coat.

ELXA

I'm sorry, I'm sorry, the Mayor
called.

JEREMY

Twice.

VICTOR

(rising, as he always
does for a woman
entering)

Chief.

ELXA

Granddaddy.

He kisses her cheek. She sits. Jeremy shakes Victor's hand
and sits beside her.

ROBERT

There she is. "If my family got
me this job, they owe me an
apology."

ELXA

(to her father, flat)

Did I lie?

ROBERT

Baby, you've never lied in your
life. It's a medical condition.
We've had you tested.

ELXA
I meant it, Daddy.

ROBERT
I know you did.

Across the table, Victor and Robert exchange a glance. It lasts a half second. Natasha sees it. So does Marc.

JEREMY
(to Marc, friendly)
Your company's in the paper again. The tsunami relief. That's good work, man. Real good work.

MARC
Thanks, Jeremy. We got lucky.

ELXA
(eating)
Nothing Marc does is luck. That's what worries me.

The table laughs. Marc laughs loudest.

Simone sets down her fork. The table goes quiet. When Simone puts down her fork, everyone does.

SIMONE
The Smilleys' lights are on.

She says it the way someone might say "the river's rising."

SIMONE (CONT'D)
I can see them from my porch.
Through the trees, across the ravine. That château of theirs.
Every window lit up like a department store.
(beat)
Fifty-three years, and they finally moved next door.

JOAN
Mother Simone, they're across a ravine. They're not next door.

SIMONE
In 1959, the Klan was on the other side of that ravine. Now it's Odessa Smilley. I'm not sure which is worse.

VICTOR

Mother.

SIMONE

I'm joking, Victor. The Klan
never had her taste in furs.

Laughter, uneasy and delighted.

MARC

You know you invited them to my
birthday.

Everyone turns.

SIMONE

(unbothered)

I invited neighbors to family
events in the bylaws of 1961. It
is not my fault the neighbors
turned out to be Smilleys.

NATASHA

Grandmama!

SIMONE

They won't come.

MARTIN

And if they do?

Simone lifts her wine and looks down the table at the
portrait of herself at twenty-five, beside the husband she
buried five years ago.

SIMONE

Then I'll wear the other pearls.

She drinks. Nobody asks what the other pearls mean.
They're all afraid to.

CUT TO:

19 EXT. DONOHUE MANOR — THE TERRACE — NIGHT

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 8:16 PM EST

A stone terrace overlooking the formal gardens, and beyond
them the dark woods of the ravine. It's cold. Their breath
fogs.

Victor stands at the balustrade with a glass of cognac.
Marc joins him with two cigars and offers one.

VICTOR

Your grandmother will smell it.

MARC

Grandma Joan smells everything.
She smelled a lie on me in 1989
and I was seven.

Victor almost laughs. He takes the cigar. Marc lights it for him with a gold lighter. They smoke and look east.

Through the bare winter trees, across the dark ravine, RAVENHURST glows: a French château with every window blazing.

VICTOR

There they are.

MARC

There they are.

VICTOR

Your great-grandfather would have walked over there tonight. With a bottle of bourbon and a smile. He'd have welcomed them to Atlanta, shaken Lucius's hand, complimented Odessa's furs, and walked home knowing exactly how many guards were at the door and which windows didn't lock.

A long beat. Victor looks at his grandson.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

You were quiet today. In the boardroom. After the doughnuts.

MARC

I'm never quiet.

VICTOR

Exactly. So when you are, I notice.

Marc says nothing. He looks at the lights.

VICTOR (CONT'D)

Martin is right about one thing. That girl is dangerous. And her father just told the whole world she's his heir.

(beat)

Heirs find each other, Marc. It's a very small club. Sooner or later, you'll be in a room with her.

MARC
I'll bring doughnuts.

VICTOR
(sharp)
You'll bring your head.

Marc turns to face him. Victor's voice is low.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
I've watched you since you were a little boy. You laugh louder than anybody in this family. You give more than anybody in this family. And you carry something heavier than anybody in this family.
(beat)
I don't know what it is. I've decided not to ask.

Marc holds his gaze. Neither blinks.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
But whatever it is you're carrying, son, carry it like a Donohue.

MARC
How's a Donohue carry it?

VICTOR
Like it weighs nothing. And never, ever set it down in front of the Smilleys.

He puts a hand on Marc's shoulder and squeezes once. Then he goes inside.

Marc stays on the terrace alone. He takes the ONYX COIN from his tuxedo pocket and turns it over in his fingers, looking at the Smilley lights.

MARC
(to himself, quietly)
Don't let them make you small.

He pockets the coin.

CUT TO:

20 INT. DONOHUE MANOR — THE LIBRARY — NIGHT*Monday, January 3, 2005 — 8:28 PM EST*

Twenty thousand books. Leather chairs. A fire. On one wall, framed, is the photograph of Joan's 1979 swearing-in as a federal judge.

Elxa stands in front of it with a cup of coffee, still in uniform. Joan enters with two slices of pound cake on china plates.

JOAN

Your brother hasn't found this one yet. Eat it before he does.

ELXA

(taking it, smiling)

Thank you, Grandma.

They sit together by the fire.

JOAN

You were very good today.

ELXA

Was I?

JOAN

You sounded like you believed every word.

ELXA

I did.

JOAN

I know. That's what made it good.

Elxa picks at the cake. She doesn't eat it.

ELXA

Can I ask you something? As a judge?

JOAN

Retired judge.

ELXA

There's no such thing.

JOAN
(amused)
Ask.

ELXA
When President Carter appointed
you. Did anybody say you only got
it because of Granddaddy?

Joan sets down her plate.

JOAN
Every single day for three years.

ELXA
What did you do?

JOAN
I made sure my opinions were so
good, they had to be read aloud
in law schools. Then I let them
keep talking.
(beat)
Elxa. Is somebody saying it?

ELXA
The whole city's saying it. My
own deputy chief smiled at the
podium while a reporter said it.

JOAN
Warren Hughes.

ELXA
You know him?

JOAN
I sentenced his brother in 1987.
He's been smiling at this family
ever since.

Elxa laughs despite herself.

ELXA
(serious again)
I just need to know that I earned
it. That nobody picked up a
phone. Because if somebody did,
Grandma... I don't know what I'd
do.

A long pause. Joan looks at her granddaughter.

Joan has no idea. But she's been married to Victor Donohue for forty-five years, and something flickers across her face: a shadow of suspicion she can't name.

JOAN
(carefully)
The law is the only thing in this family that nobody can buy. That's why I chose it.
(beat)
If you ever find out somebody tried, you come to me first.

ELXA
Why you?

JOAN
Because I'll know which husband to kill.

Elxa laughs. Joan smiles, but her eyes stay on the fire.

CUT TO:

21 EXT. RAVENHURST – THE STONE TERRACE – NIGHT
Monday, January 3, 2005 – 8:42 PM EST

A long balustrade overlooking the ravine. Through the trees to the west, the Summit of Belmont Crest glows: the white Georgian palace of Donohue Manor, and the lamps along Sovereign Way.

Esther stands at the railing in a long coat over her pajamas, holding a cup of tea that's gone cold.

Her RAZR buzzes in her coat pocket. She takes it out.

INSERT – PHONE SCREEN: "SEBASTIAN (LONDON) – INCOMING CALL"

She looks at it. She lets it ring. She presses DECLINE.

Behind her, the terrace doors open. Odessa emerges in a floor-length white satin robe and the mink, with a glass of brandy and an aide following at a respectful distance.

ODESSA
(to the aide)
Go to bed, Marisol. I'm eighty-four, not dying.

The aide retreats. Odessa joins Esther at the railing.

Odessa sips her brandy and looks west toward the lights.

ODESSA (CONT'D)
Somewhere over there, Simone
Donohue is looking back at us.
I'd bet my brooch on it.

ESTHER
Grandma. Can I ask you something?

ODESSA
You're going to.

ESTHER
Why do we hate them?

Odessa turns and looks at her granddaughter for a long moment.

ODESSA
Baby, that's the first time in
twenty-two years anybody in this
family has asked me that.

ESTHER
And?

ODESSA
(slowly)
In 1952, your great-grandfather
and Alexander Donohue sat down in
a house in Savannah to sign
papers that would have made them
partners. The two biggest Black
hotel men in America. One
company. Coast to coast.
(beat)
And at the last minute, Alexander
tore it up. Walked out. Built
hotels in every city your
great-grandfather wanted.
Cornelius spent the rest of his
life watching Donohue lights go
up where Smilley lights should
have been.

ESTHER
Why did he tear it up?

ODESSA
(a long pause)
That's the question, isn't it.

She sips.

ODESSA (CONT'D)

Cornelius said Alexander was a thief. The Donohues say Cornelius was a liar.

(beat)

And your grandmother has spent fifty-three years wondering if they were both right.

Esther looks at the Manor's lights.

ESTHER

And now we live next door.

ODESSA

Now we live next door.

(she turns to go, then stops)

Esther. Whatever you're keeping from this family...

Esther goes very still.

ODESSA (CONT'D)

...keep it better than Simone Donohue keeps hers.

She goes inside.

Esther stands alone at the railing. Across the ravine, a figure steps out onto the terrace of Donohue Manor, small with distance. A man in a tuxedo, with the glowing point of a cigar.

She can't see his face. She doesn't need to.

She watches him. He watches the Smilley lights.

Neither knows the other is looking.

FADE OUT.

ACT SIX**22 EXT. PIEDMONT PARK — THE PATH ALONG LAKE CLARA MEER — NIGHT**

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 9:52 PM EST

Midtown's skyline glitters beyond the black water of the lake. The park is empty and cold. Old-fashioned lamps throw pools of yellow light along the path.

A DOG WALKER, a middle-aged man in a Georgia Tech beanie, is being tugged along by a golden retriever that has caught a scent. The dog strains toward a stand of bushes near the water's edge.

DOG WALKER

Biscuit. Biscuit, no. Leave it.
Biscuit!

The dog BARKS and barks at the bushes. The man sighs, pulls out a keychain flashlight, and pushes the branches aside.

The beam lands on a MAN'S HAND, palm up in the dead leaves, not moving.

The hand is CLOSED around something.

The dog walker staggers back. His flashlight drops.

DOG WALKER (CONT'D)

Oh God. Oh God. Oh God—

He fumbles for his phone.

CUT TO:

23 INT. DONOHUE MANOR — THE FRONT FOYER — NIGHT

Monday, January 3, 2005 — 10:08 PM EST

A double staircase and a black-and-white marble floor. The family is spilling out of the dining room. Coats and good-byes. Winston hands Jasmine her coat, and a DRIVER carries her garment bags out to a waiting car.

JASMINE

(kissing Victor)

Wheels up in fifty minutes. I'll
call when I land.

VICTOR
Wear the navy.

JASMINE
Everybody in this family knows
about the navy!

Peter helps her into her coat. Joan hugs her tight.

JOAN
Give 'em hell, baby.

JASMINE
Always, Mama.

At the foot of the stairs, Elxa's cell phone rings. Two
seconds later, Jeremy's pager goes off.

They look at each other. Elxa answers.

ELXA
(into phone)
Jackson.
(listening)
Where?
(beat)
How long ago?
(beat, her face
hardening)
In his hand? What kind of—
(she stops, glancing at
the family)
Don't say another word on this
line. I'm on my way.

She hangs up. Jeremy is already pulling on his coat.

JEREMY
Where?

ELXA
Piedmont. By the lake.

GRACE
What happened?

ELXA
(already moving)
Nothing for dinner conversation.
Granddaddy, Grandma—

JOAN
Go. Be careful.

Across the foyer, Marc leans against the banister with his hands in his pockets.

MARC
(lightly)
Everything okay, Chief?

ELXA
(pulling on her gloves,
not stopping)
A body in Piedmont Park. Probably
a mugging.
(beat, lower, only to
Jeremy, as she passes
Marc)
The responding officer says
there's a coin in his hand.

It's barely audible. She doesn't see Marc's face as she passes, because she isn't looking at him. She's looking at the door.

But we see it.

For one fraction of a second, the easy, laughing heir is gone. Something utterly still takes his place.

Then it's gone. He smiles and opens the door for her.

MARC
Be safe, sis.

ELXA
Always am.

She and Jeremy are out into the night. Blue lights flash on the dash of her unmarked Crown Victoria as it roars down Sovereign Way.

Marc watches them go. Behind him, Natasha is watching him.

NATASHA
Baby. You all right?

MARC
(turning, bright)
Mama, I ate four pieces of
cornbread. I'm fantastic.

He kisses her cheek, grabs his coat from Winston, and walks out into the dark.

Natasha watches the door close behind her son. A mother knows when not to know. She's decided that for years.

Tonight, it looks harder.

CUT TO:

24 EXT. PIEDMONT PARK – CRIME SCENE – NIGHT

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 10:41 PM EST

The lakeside path is a sea of flashing blue and red. Yellow tape. Portable floodlights turn the night into an operating room.

A crowd has gathered at the tape: late-night joggers, neighbors in bathrobes, a couple from a Midtown bar still holding their drinks.

Elxa ducks under the tape, still in dress blues under her overcoat. Jeremy follows. Officers straighten as she passes. The Chief doesn't usually come to scenes.

Deputy Chief Hughes is already there, in a trench coat, hands in his pockets.

ELXA

What do we have, Warren?

In the bushes, a MEDICAL EXAMINER in a Tyvek suit crouches over a shape under a sheet.

MEDICAL EXAMINER

Black male, early forties. Single gunshot wound, close range. No wallet, no ID. Time of death, three to four hours ago, give or take.

JEREMY

Robbery?

MEDICAL EXAMINER

He's still wearing a Rolex. Not a robbery.

ELXA

The officer said something was in his hand.

The M.E. nods and lifts the edge of the sheet. Only the dead man's HAND is visible, still clenched.

With a gloved finger, the M.E. gently opens it.

In the dead palm, under the floodlights, lies a polished
BLACK ONYX COIN.

A CROWN, engraved above a WAVE.

Silence at the scene. Jeremy crouches and looks without
touching.

JEREMY
(quietly)
Blackwater.

ELXA
(sharp, low)
Nobody says that word out loud.
(to everyone in
earshot)
Nobody.

She looks at the coin. Fourteen days as Chief. She stood
at a podium this morning and promised the city she'd find
Sovereign. Tonight, Sovereign has found her.

JEREMY
They leave these when they want
people to know it was them. Every
time. Harlow in 2000. The
Southside warehouses last summer.

ELXA
They don't kill people in public
parks, Jeremy.

JEREMY
Maybe they do now.

ELXA
Or maybe somebody wants us to
think they do.

Jeremy looks at her. She's thinking. She's very good at
this.

ELXA (CONT'D)
Bag it. Photograph it. I want
every onyx supplier in the
Southeast by morning. And I want
to know who this man was before
the press does.

A commotion at the tape. Headlights. A news van with a WBKG satellite dish on its roof screeches to the curb.

Celeste Vaughn jumps out of the passenger seat. The red coat. A cameraman is right behind her.

ELXA (CONT'D)
(turning slowly to
Hughes)
How does WBKG know about a body
in Piedmont Park forty-five
minutes after the call?

HUGHES
(innocent)
Scanners, Chief. Everybody's got
a scanner.

Elxa stares at him. He smiles. She walks toward the tape.

CELESTE
(calling out)
Chief Jackson! Chief! Is it true
the victim was found holding a
Blackwater coin?

Elxa stops dead. Jeremy's head snaps toward Hughes. Hughes is studying the lake.

ELXA
(to Celeste,
controlled)
No comment.

CELESTE
Is Sovereign killing people now,
Chief? Is Atlanta safe?

ELXA
No. Comment.

She turns her back on the cameras.

Celeste turns to her cameraman, eyes shining.

CELESTE
We go live at eleven. Top of the
show.

CUT TO:

25 INT. THE BULLOCK PAVILION – LIVING ROOM – NIGHT
Monday, January 3, 2005 – 11:04 PM EST

Marc's home: glass and stone cantilevered over the river bluff, with a wall of windows showing black water and bare trees. It's minimalist and beautiful, and it's empty. It's a house built for a big family, and only one person lives in it.

Marc sits alone on the edge of a white sofa with his tuxedo tie undone. A glass of bourbon sits untouched on the table. A huge TV is tuned to WBKG.

On the screen, Celeste stands in front of the crime scene tape, the blue lights strobing behind her.

CELESTE (ON TV)
—police are not confirming the identity of the victim, but multiple sources tell WBKG that the man was found clutching a black onyx coin, the notorious calling card of the shadowy criminal organization known as the Blackwater Syndicate.

Marc doesn't move.

CELESTE (ON TV) (CONT'D)
Just this morning, newly sworn-in Police Chief Elxa Jackson vowed to find the Syndicate's mysterious leader, known only as "Sovereign." Tonight, the question on every Atlanta resident's mind: has Sovereign declared war on this city?
(beat)
Reporting live from Piedmont Park, I'm Celeste Vaughn, WBKG Action News.

His RAZR buzzes on the coffee table. He looks at it.

INSERT – TEXT MESSAGE FROM "CELESTE": "Big story tonight!! Can't do dinner. Rain check? xoxo C"

He looks at the text. He looks at the TV. He types:

INSERT – TEXT: "Proud of you. Be careful out there."

He sends it and sets the phone down.

He picks up the bourbon at last, looks at it, and sets it back down without drinking.

26 INT. MARTIN OLSON'S LOFT – MIDTOWN – SAME TIME

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 11:06 PM EST

A converted industrial loft: exposed brick, steel beams, and floor-to-ceiling windows looking toward Piedmont Park. It's immaculate. Every book is shelved by height. Nothing is out of place.

Martin stands at the window in shirtsleeves, a crystal tumbler of scotch in his hand. Several blocks away, beyond the rooftops, blue police lights pulse in the trees of Piedmont Park.

On a TV behind him, muted, Celeste's report replays. The same crime scene tape and the same blue lights.

Martin watches the real lights through the window rather than the ones on the screen.

He takes a slow sip of scotch.

Then he raises his glass, very slightly, toward the park.

His expression doesn't change at all.

CUT TO:

27 EXT. BELMONT CREST – THE RIVER GATE BOATHOUSE – NIGHT

Monday, January 3, 2005 – 11:41 PM EST

The Chattahoochee in the dark. No moon. Black water and the sound of the current. A single iron lantern burns over the boathouse door.

Marc walks down the bluff path in his tuxedo pants and a black overcoat, hands in his pockets. He's alone.

At the end of the dock, a figure is waiting in the dark. As Marc steps into the lantern light, the figure turns.

Amond.

Neither says hello.

AMOND

You saw it.

MARC

I saw it.

AMOND

Saint called me twenty minutes ago. His people are hearing it all over the Southside. They think it's us. They think we've started something.

Marc walks to the end of the dock and looks at the black water.

AMOND (CONT'D)

(low)

Marc.

(beat)

That's our coin.

A long, long silence. The river runs.

When Marc turns around, the man from Egleston and the dinner table is gone. There's no smile and no warmth. His face is perfectly still, and there's something ancient and cold in his eyes.

For the first time, we are looking at SOVEREIGN.

MARC

(very quiet)

I never gave that order.

AMOND

I know.

MARC

Nobody at the Table gave that order.

AMOND

I know.

MARC

Then somebody in this city just stole my name, walked into a public park, and signed it in blood.

(beat)

On the same day my sister promised the whole city she'd find me.

He takes the onyx coin from his pocket and holds it up to the lantern light. The crown. The wave.

MARC (CONT'D)
Wake up the Seven.

AMOND
All of them?

MARC
All of them.
(beat)
Whoever did this wanted a war.
(he closes his fist
around the coin)
Let's not keep them waiting.

He turns back toward the black water. The lantern flickers.

HOLD on Sovereign, standing at the edge of the river.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE #0001

NEXT ON BEYOND THE KINGDOM...

- In Washington, JASMINE raises her right hand in the House chamber: "I do solemnly swear..."
- MARTIN, alone in his loft, answers his phone: "I watched it from my window. Yes... Exactly as you said it would."
- In the Phipps Plaza parking deck, HARMONY shoves a car seat into AMOND's arms: "Your MOTHER, Amond? Your MOTHER?!" AMOND: "I didn't know!" LYRIC (from the car seat): "Mommy's yelling!"
- At the River Gate, seven shadowed figures around a table with an EMPTY EIGHTH CHAIR. MARC, at its head: "Somebody's using our coin."

FADE TO BLACK.